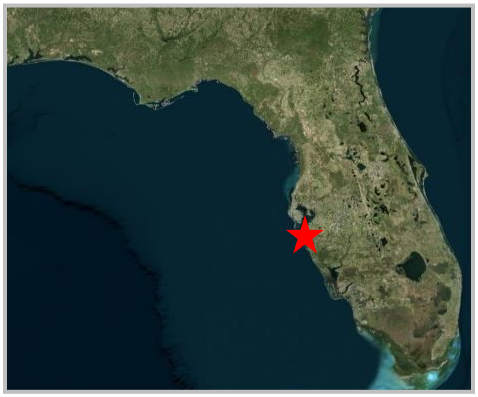
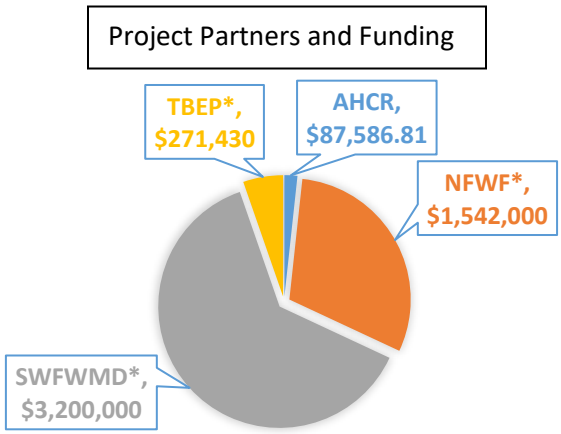
Robinson Preserve Expansion Restoration, Manatee County, FL

FY 20/21





*Partner funding grants to Manatee County

Project Description

Robinson Preserve, located between two estuaries of national significance on a peninsula between Tampa and Sarasota Bays, is a Manatee County park featuring 705 acres of coastal habitats and recreational amenities. Through a partnership between Manatee County, the National Fish and Wildlife Foundation (NFWF), Southwest Florida Water Management District (SWFWMD), Tampa Bay Estuary Program (TBEP), the National Oceanic And Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), and FWC, the Robinson Preserve Expansion Restoration project enhanced mangrove, seagrass, oyster, saltmarsh, and coastal upland habitat and created new amenities such as trails and a paddle craft launch within the 149 acre Expansion area. Tidal creeks, lagoons, and ponds were sculpted out of fallow farmland and their shores covered with hundreds of native trees, wildflowers, seagrass meadows, and oyster reefs to create an abundance of fish and wildlife habitat.



Figure 1: Enhanced oyster reef, mangrove, tidal creek, and upland habitats. February 5, 2021.

Habitat construction, oyster reef restoration, invasive plant control, and aquatic revegetation were completed by Manatee County using $5,013,430 in grants from partner organizations. AHCR provided appropriation funding that was used complete soil preparation and planting of native trees, shrubs, and grasses to enhance maritime hammock wildlife habitat.

Benefits

- Provide foraging habitat for a variety of wildlife including songbirds, waterfowl, wading birds, diving birds, shorebirds. fish, and crabs.

MESS Strategic Plan Elements Supported

• Strategic Action 1.1.1: Identify and develop restoration projects in marine and estuarine habitats (e.g. mangroves, seagrass, saltmarsh, oyster reef, coral reef) on publicly owned state lands including those on conservation lands acquired through non-regulatory means.
• Strategic Action 1.1.4: Implement priority restoration plans.

Acreage restored by habitat type (footprint)

Total- 59.5 acres aquatic habitat:

- Freshwater non-forested marsh – 2.6 acres
- Saltmarsh – 16.5 acres
- Mangrove – 5.2 acres
- Oyster reef – 2.1 acres
- Estuarine subtidal – 33.1 acres

Total- 55.8 acres upland habitat:

- Pine flatwoods – 14.0 acres
- Maritime hammock – 41.8 acres

Acreage affected by restoration activities: 4,812 acres of intertidal and soft-bottom estuarine habitat, and 35 acres of freshwater non-forested wetland habitat within the hydrologic unit.



Figure 2: Tidal marsh and upland habitat immediately after restoration. February 5, 2021